

BONUS 5 OF 5 · FREE WITH YOUR COLLECTION

Yarn Guide & Shopping List

T-shirt yarn, cotton cord or cotton yarn? How much to buy for each size, the right hook for each yarn and the list to get started without waste.

Yarn comparison

Amounts by size

Hook chart

Printable lists



What's inside

1. T-shirt yarn vs. macramé cord vs. cotton	3
2. Which yarn for which backpack	4
3. How much to buy — by backpack size	4
4. The right hook for each yarn	5
5. Brands & where to buy	6
6. Printable shopping lists	7

SECTION 1

1. T-shirt yarn vs. macramé cord vs. cotton

Three families, three completely different bags. Choose the yarn first — the pattern follows.



	T-SHIRT YARN	MACRAMÉ CORD (3–5 MM)	COTTON YARN (DK / WORSTED)
What it is	Strips of jersey fabric (often recycled) rolled into a tube	Single-strand or braided cotton string	Spun cotton, classic yarn weights #3 / #4
Look	Chunky, bold, modern	Boho, structured, natural	Fine stitches, detail, any color
Speed	Very fast	Fast	Slower
Structure	Holds shape well	Very firm; stands on its own	Soft; needs lining for heavy loads
Weight of a finished medium bag	Heavy (1.3–1.5 kg)	Medium (0.8 kg with 3 mm)	Light (about 350 g)
Watch out for	Width and stretch change between cones and dye lots	Frays at the ends; stiff on the hands	Can stretch; straps need a core
Price (2026, typical)	\$10–14 per 500–600 g cone	\$10–15 per 100 m (3 mm)	\$3–4 per 50–70 g ball

AVOID FOR BACKPACKS

Acrylic and cotton-acrylic blends are soft and cheap but they **stretch and pill** under weight. Use them for decorations, never for bag bodies or straps.

SECTION 2

2. Which yarn for which backpack

BACKPACK	BEST YARN	WHY	HOOK
Kids / school	Worsted cotton, lined	Light, washable, bright colors	4.5 mm (7)
Daily city backpack	Worsted or bulky cotton + webbing straps	Comfortable, elegant, light	4.5–6 mm
Mini fashion backpack	T-shirt yarn or 3 mm cord	Structured shape in a few hours	9 mm / 5 mm
Boho / beach	3 mm or 5 mm macramé cord	Firm, sand shakes off, natural look	5–6 mm
Drawstring backpack	3 mm cord or worsted cotton	Soft enough to gather	5 mm / 4.5 mm
Large travel backpack	Worsted cotton, fully lined	The only option light enough to carry full	4.5 mm (7)

T-SHIRT YARN LIMIT

Use t-shirt yarn for **mini and small** sizes. A large t-shirt yarn backpack weighs 2 kg (4.4 lb) empty.

DYE LOT RULE

Buy all the yarn for one bag from the **same dye lot** (the lot number on the label), plus one extra ball or 10%. A second lot almost never matches exactly.

SECTION 3

3. How much to buy

Amounts for a backpack in single crochet with flap and straps, +15% safety margin included.

SIZE (W X H X D)	WORSTED COTTON	3 MM CORD	5 MM CORD	T-SHIRT YARN
Mini · 20 × 22 × 8 cm 8 × 8.75 × 3 in	170 g · 260 m / 285 yd 3 balls of 70 g	400 g · 150 m	770 g · 110 m	750 g · 90 m 2 cones

SIZE (W X H X D)	WORSTED COTTON	3 MM CORD	5 MM CORD	T-SHIRT YARN
Small · 24 × 28 × 10 cm 9.5 × 11 × 4 in	250 g · 385 m / 420 yd 4 balls	600 g · 220 m	1.15 kg · 165 m	1.1 kg · 130 m 2 cones
Medium · 28 × 32 × 12 cm 11 × 12.5 × 4.75 in	340 g · 520 m / 570 yd 5 balls	810 g · 300 m	1.6 kg · 230 m	not recommended
Large · 32 × 38 × 14 cm 12.5 × 15 × 5.5 in	450 g · 690 m / 755 yd 7 balls	1.05 kg · 390 m	not recommended	not recommended

Adjust for the stitch

STITCH IN THE PATTERN	MULTIPLY THE AMOUNT BY
Single crochet, hdc, moss/linen stitch	x 1.0
Double crochet, V-stitch, shells	x 0.9 (more open)
Waistcoat stitch	x 1.15 (denser)
Bobbles, puffs, post stitches, basketweave in bands	x 1.2
Bobbles or popcorns all over	x 1.3

THE SWATCH METHOD (±5%)

Crochet a 10 × 10 cm (4 × 4 in) square in your stitch and weigh it on a kitchen scale. Multiply by the surface of the bag (Mini 1,900 cm² · Small 2,900 · Medium 3,900 · Large 5,100, all pieces and straps) and divide by 100. Add 15%. It is the most exact number you can get.

SECTION 4

4. The right hook for each yarn

For bags, go 0.5–1 mm smaller than the label says: tighter stitches = firmer bag that holds its shape.

YARN	LABEL SAYS	USE FOR BAGS	GAUGE (SC, 10 CM / 4 IN)
DK cotton (#3)	4 mm (G-6)	3.5 mm (E-4)	20 sts x 22 rows
Worsted cotton (#4)	5 mm (H-8)	4.5 mm (7)	16 sts x 18 rows
Bulky cotton (#5)	6.5 mm (K-10.5)	6 mm (J-10)	12 sts x 13 rows

YARN	LABEL SAYS	USE FOR BAGS	GAUGE (SC, 10 CM / 4 IN)
3 mm cotton cord	5–6 mm	5 mm (H-8)	14 sts x 15 rows
5 mm cotton cord	7–8 mm	6 mm (J-10)	12 sts x 13 rows
T-shirt yarn, thin (under 1.5 cm wide)	8–9 mm	8 mm (L-11)	10 sts x 11 rows
T-shirt yarn, standard	10 mm	9 mm (M/N-13)	9 sts x 10 rows
T-shirt yarn, thick	12 mm	10 mm (N/P-15)	8 sts x 9 rows

QUICK FIX

Stitches look loose and the bag slumps? Go down one hook size. Fabric is like cardboard and your wrist hurts? Go up one size.

COMFORT

For t-shirt yarn and cord, use **plastic or wooden hooks** with a large handle: aluminum hooks at 9–10 mm are heavy and slippery.

SECTION 5

5. Brands & where to buy

Well-known options in the US, UK, Canada, Australia and New Zealand. No brand pays us to be here.

YARN TYPE	EASY-TO-FIND BRANDS	WHERE
Worsted cotton	Lily Sugar'n Cream, Lion Brand 24/7 Cotton, Paintbox Yarns Cotton Aran, Hobbii Rainbow Cotton 8/8	Big-box craft stores, online yarn shops, Amazon
DK cotton	Paintbox Yarns Cotton DK, Scheepjes Catona / Softfun, Drops Paris	Online yarn shops, local yarn stores
Macramé / cotton cord	Bobbiny, generic 3 mm and 5 mm single-strand cotton cord	Craft stores (macramé aisle), Etsy suppliers, Amazon
T-shirt yarn	Hoooked Zpagetti / RibbonXL, generic t-shirt yarn cones	Craft stores, online yarn shops, Etsy
Hardware & lining	Bag-making hardware kits, quilting cotton fat quarters	Fabric stores, craft stores, online

CRAFT STORES

Michaels, Hobby Lobby and Walmart (US); Hobbycraft (UK); Michaels and DeSerres (CA); Spotlight (AU/NZ). See the color in real light and buy the whole dye lot in one trip.

ONLINE

Bigger ranges and better prices by volume (cones and 10-ball packs). Order a single ball first to check the color, then the rest of the lot — and ask the seller to ship one dye lot.

T-SHIRT YARN WARNING

Buy t-shirt yarn from the same seller for a whole collection: two brands with the same "width" can be 30% thicker or thinner, and your sizes will not match the pattern.

SECTION 6

6. Printable shopping lists

Tick what you already have. Buy only what's left — nothing here is "just in case".

Starter kit — any first backpack

- ☐ Hook for your yarn (Section 4) + one size smaller
- ☐ 20 locking stitch markers
- ☐ 2 blunt tapestry needles (large eye) + 1 sharp sewing needle
- ☐ Small sharp scissors
- ☐ Measuring tape (cm / in)
- ☐ Upholstery or bonded nylon thread
- ☐ 20 fabric clips
- ☐ Project bag or box to keep the dye lot together

Mini t-shirt yarn backpack (20 x 22 x 8 cm)

- ☐ 2 cones t-shirt yarn, same seller (750 g)
- ☐ 9 mm (M/N-13) plastic hook
- ☐ 2 D-rings + 2 slides, 20 mm
- ☐ 1.2 m / 1.3 yd webbing, 20 mm
- ☐ 1 magnetic snap 18 mm + plastic canvas square

Medium cotton backpack (28 x 32 x 12 cm)

- ☐ 5 balls worsted cotton, same dye lot (340 g)
- ☐ +1 ball in a contrast color (edging / straps)
- ☐ 2 slide adjusters + 2 D-rings, 25 mm
- ☐ 1.75 m / 1.9 yd cotton webbing, 25 mm
- ☐ 1 magnetic snap 14 mm or 16 in two-way zipper
- ☐ 1 fat quarter quilting cotton (lining)
- ☐ Felt scraps for backings

Boho cord backpack, small (24 x 28 x 10 cm)

- ☐ 600 g / 220 m cotton cord 3 mm
- ☐ 5 mm (H-8) hook
- ☐ 12 metal eyelets 10 mm + setting tool
- ☐ 1.7 m / 1.9 yd cord for the drawstring + 1 cord stopper
- ☐ Leather straps 60 cm with rivets, or 1.4 m webbing
- ☐ Fray check for cord ends

Don't buy yet (it's what gets wasted)

- ☐ Hook sets of 20 sizes — you'll use 3
- ☐ Yarn "because it was on sale" in a lot you'll never finish
- ☐ Sewing machine — every step in this collection is done by hand
- ☐ Hardware in 3 metal colors — pick one finish and stay with it

Buy once. Buy right.

One dye lot, the right hook, the exact amount. Everything else is just stitches.

The Crochet Backpack Collection